CONGRESS WORKERS KNOW COME WHAT MAY, GANDHIS WON'T COMPROMISE ON PARTY IDEOLOGY"

Former Union Minister **Ajay Maken** is a Rahul Gandhi favourite. A CWC member, he is also the general secretary in-charge of Rajasthan, one of the two states where the party is in power. Speaking to **Kaushik Deka**, he demonstrates how the current crisis in the Congress can be an opportunity for younger leaders to prove themselves



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Q. Why does the Congress find itself in an existential crisis?
No doubt, our electoral performance in the recent past has not been very encouraging. But it would be foolish to write us off. We got 19.5 per cent of the votes in the 2019 general election. When the BJP, after slipping to 18.8 per cent in 2009, can bounce back to its present position of strength, how can you use the phrase "existential crisis" for the Congress? We are the oldest political party in the country, steeped in a traditional political style, which was quite successful in those times. But times have changed, the tools of democracy have evolved, and so has the mode of communication with the electorate. Personally, I think we were slower than our opponents in responding to this challenge in the past two decades. Moreover, if we look at the trends globally, political parties with right-wing ideologies are winning. India cannot remain untouched.

Q. How do you see the future of the Congress—in the next few assembly polls and in 2024?
We invest all that we have to win elections. After all, it is an ideological battle. It is a quest to empower those who have been disenfranchised by a totalitarian government drunk high on the power of their majority numbers.

Q. Many have criticised the leadership issue in the Congress. They say the Gandhis are no more relevant to the Congress. Can there be a non-Gandhi leader of the Congress?
This question is prejudiced. An overwhelming majority of the Congress workers want Rahul Gandhi as president. Gandhis are our leaders because Congress workers have complete faith in them and we believe that come what may, they will not compromise on the party's ideology, which genuinely represents this great nation of ours.

Q. What's the Congress narrative to make a young voter vote for you?
Even if a young voter does not want to delve too deep into history, I may like to say just one thing. Under Manmohan Singh and Narasimha Rao, the Indian government had been exemplary. We liberalised the economy, and later, 140 million people were taken out of poverty. Be it the 1991 economic crisis or the 2007 recession, we faced it. Now compare it with BJP rule. Their response to inflation, price rise, growing disparity and economic uncertainty is polarisation induced by bulldozers, loudspeakers, hijab and Hanuman Chalisa. Polarising the majority against the rest will have serious ramifications, which the youth and future generations will have to bear.

"If we look at the trends globally, political parties with right-wing ideologies have been winning. India cannot remain untouched by such developments"

Q. The Congress hardly has young, upcoming mass leaders in the states. Several of your contemporaries have quit the party. The veterans are past their prime.
Adversity is a test of true leadership. Unfortunately, many of my contemporaries, whom our party recognised and developed over the years, left us to join a party with a diametrically opposite political view. However, the position we are in is an opportunity for youngsters to climb up the ladder.

Q. Instead of being the pivot of Opposition unity, Congress is alienating parties. Is it because of the ambition of their leaders or the arrogance of the Congress leadership, as they allege?
Parties like AAP and TMC help BJP win elections in different parts of the country. Outside their states, they contest elections to divide Congress votes. ■